

Contending for the Faith

Tent-Revival Hunger Left Me With Miracles but No Path Into Them

I was born again at the end of the tent-revival era. I had the privilege of catching a few meetings with tent revivalists such as A. A. Allen and Leroy Jenkins, and I was in Kathryn Kuhlman's meetings.

As an ultra-Pentecostal Holiness boy, some of the concepts I was taught about salvation confused me. I did not know for certain that I was saved until I understood righteousness. Legalism kept me in question. No matter how well I did, the devil would come and tell me it was not good enough, and I would wonder again whether I was saved.

But I also saw God use men in miracle-working power. We had an old A. A. Allen tape where he asked a woman, "What happened to you, little mama?" She said she had fallen, broken her back, and had not walked in five years. He prayed in the name of Jesus, the crowd began screaming, and he said, "There she goes, running across the platform." Then he would say, "Bring me another wheelchair," and it would happen again.

I had seen those kinds of miracles, but I did not understand the call on my own life. I did not know how to answer the hunger inside me or even how to begin. I worked in the mills in Oregon, and after work I would sometimes take a baseball bat and pound pine trees out of frustration. The call of God was so heavy on me, and I had no clue how to enter it.

I meet people all the time with that same hunger. It may be in helps, governments, or another ministry, but there is an intense desire to fulfill whatever God has called them to do.

What frustrated me was that these men preached about mighty miracles continually, but none of them ever told you what you had to begin doing so God could qualify you, give to you, and use you in that power.

A Vision Forced Me Out of Frustration and Into the Prayer Closet

One morning God had mercy on me through a vision. I opened my eyes expecting to see the bedroom, but instead I saw a young woman preaching beautifully in a meeting. The power of God was heavy. I knew it was supposed to be my meeting, but for some reason I had not answered the call.

Several people got out of wheelchairs. Then she looked at me, the crowd disappeared, and it was only the two of us. She said, "I don't know why God has given me this ministry. One of you men must have failed."

That did not mean God does not call women. He calls women as He calls men. But in that vision she had become a second choice because I had failed to take my place. I may be a second choice for someone else's first choice; I do not know. But I knew He had to put her in because I had failed.

When my wife woke up, I turned to her and said, "I cannot take this anymore. Swim, sink, eat beans, sleep under a tree, dress the kids in gunny sacks, live in the church; I do not care. I am going full time."

So I began reporting to the prayer closet.

Praying in Tongues Became the Only Way I Knew to Stay With God

I started reporting to an eight-by-eight prayer closet in the church at 5:30 or 6:00 in the morning, when the mill whistle would have blown. I figured that if I was going full time, I should put in the hours I would normally have put in at the mill.

I locked myself in. First I exhausted myself praying in English. Then I switched to praying in tongues. I was Pentecostal Holiness, filled with the Holy Ghost, and I knew I could speak with tongues. There was conflict among the elders about whether a person could speak in tongues any time he wanted to, but I elected that I could because I did not know how else to spend those hours.

After fifteen or twenty minutes in English, I would sit on the floor or walk back and forth in that little room praying in tongues. I did it simply because I did not know what else to do. It was in that closet that God taught me what nobody else had taught me.

Hunger Without the Word Made Me Vulnerable to Every Wind of Doctrine

I was so hungry that if anyone told me something would bring more of the miracle-working power of God into my life, I was willing to jump and do it. I did not know the Word, and that hunger made me a victim of every wind of doctrine.

One group told me, "No wonder you do not walk in power. Look at that jewelry." I was only wearing a watch and a ring, but if jewelry was keeping me from power, I was ready to take it off. Before I took it off, I was a powerless jewelry-wearing Pentecostal boy. After I took it off, I was a powerless non-jewelry-wearing Pentecostal boy.

Then another group came along and said, "No wonder you do not walk in power. How were you baptized?" I said, "In the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit." They said, "You have been baptized into three gods. There is only one God. You must be rebaptized."

It was the middle of winter. The pond was frozen. Bathtubs would not do for religion, and somehow even a swimming pool seemed too comfortable. They dragged a tire down, burned it, cracked the ice, and baptized me. The man doing the baptizing turned blue. I jumped in, he

grabbed me, shoved me under, and I came up frozen stiff: still powerless, now baptized in the name of one God.

Anything that promised to fulfill the hunger inside me, I would ask, "How high and how far do I jump?"

Your hunger may be different from mine. You may not be called to the same thing. But I cannot understand any person not having a God-hunger that drives him all the way into relationship with Him.

Jude Commands Us to Contend and Then Shows Us How

Imagine how I felt when I found Jude 3:

Beloved, when I gave all diligence to write unto you of the common salvation, it was needful for me to write unto you, and exhort you that ye should earnestly contend for the faith which was once delivered unto the saints.

After years of meditation, God confirmed this to me again and again: Paul, Jesus, and every teacher inspired by the Holy Spirit will not tell you to do something without also telling you how to do it.

It is not enough to know that I should earnestly contend for the faith once delivered to the saints. My heart's cry for years had been, "For God's sake, would somebody please tell me how?"

Jude said we should contend for the same kind of faith the early church walked in. When I saw that kind of faith, I knew we had a lot of contending to do. In the book of Acts, they laid the sick in the streets so that Peter's shadow might fall on them, and people from the cities around brought every disease imaginable, and they were healed.

By the time Jude wrote his epistle, men had already crept in unaware and begun destroying the faith of the early church. If Jude says that faith is contendable, then it is contendable.

Clouds Without Water Cannot Produce What They Advertise

God made me meditate on Jude to find out what traps I must avoid so my own faith would not be destroyed. Jude called those men clouds without water, trees twice dead and plucked up by the roots, raging waves of the sea foaming out their own shame, and wandering stars.

They were "twice dead" because they had been dead once, became alive, and then were deceived. Wandering stars blaze out of darkness for a moment and disappear back into the darkness they came from. Waves rise out of the sea of people, make a show, and then vanish back into the same sea.

But my favorite label is this: clouds without water.

They come over the horizon looking good and sounding good, but when they get overhead they cannot produce because they have no water. From Genesis to Revelation, whenever the Holy Spirit is likened to something, He is likened to water.

Jesus said:

He that believeth on me, as the scripture hath said, out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water.

So the first criterion for contending for the faith once delivered to the saints is that I must be full of the Holy Spirit. He is the only One qualified to wage this contending from the inside out and mortify the things in my life that keep me from contending rightly.

We do not have to be clouds without water. We have the Holy Spirit.

The Holy Spirit Keeps Us From Sensual Separation From Truth

Jude 19 says:

These be they who separate themselves, sensual, having not the Spirit.

Who are "they"? The clouds without water, the wandering stars, the trees twice dead, the waves foaming out their own shame. Jude labels them as those who separate themselves.

They are sensual, sense-ruled, dominated by carnality, and they do not have the Spirit. That tells me the Holy Spirit is essential if I am not going to be dominated by my senses.

What do they separate themselves from? In context, Jude has just told us to contend for the faith once delivered to the saints. They separated themselves from the doctrine and original teaching set forth by the apostles.

Jesus commissioned the Holy Spirit to guide us into all truth. Jesus said, "Thy word is truth." John wrote that concerning those who seduce you, you have no need that any man teach you, because the anointing you received abides in you and is truth.

That does not abolish the office of teacher; otherwise I would not have a job. It means that when someone is trying to seduce you through teaching, the anointing within you bears witness to truth and exposes deception.

That is why Jude 19 and 20 are one thought:

These be they who separate themselves, sensual, having not the Spirit. But ye, beloved, building up yourselves on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost.

You build yourself up above susceptibility to deception, above a sense-ruled walk, by praying in the Holy Ghost.

Faith People Need More Than the Creed of Faith

Let us bring this down to the level of faith. Every group has a creed. Foursquare has its creed. The Assemblies of God have their bylaws and statements of belief. If faith people had a simple creed, it would be this:

I am not moved by what I see, hear, or feel. I am only moved by what I believe, and I take the Word of God as the final say-so in my life.

If my body says I am sick, I do not ask my body for the final say-so. My body has sensory organs and will report the condition it is in. But when my body is sick, it does not agree with the Word, so I do not ask it for the final answer.

I ask the Word of God. I ask the Holy Spirit. I ask Jesus. They all agree. Jesus said, "My words, they are spirit, and they are life." The Holy Spirit represents Jesus' words because they are spirit and life.

Two thousand years ago, your disease was nailed to the cross. It is not up to God anymore; it is up to you to agree with what He has said. If we had a creed, we would say, "I take the Word of God as the final say-so."

But it takes the walk of the Spirit to execute the final say-so of the Word in your life. Otherwise your carnality will cancel you out.

The Word Established Me, but Prayer Gave Me Stamina to Stand

When I first began praying in the Holy Ghost and being indoctrinated in the Word, I listened to so many Kenneth Hagin and Kenneth Copeland tapes that I could preach their messages. I could preach Brother Hagin's testimony almost better than he did. I thought he left out details. I could preach Copeland's faith teaching too.

There was just one little problem: like many people, I could make faith sound much better than I could make it work.

I did not want disease to track me down and cleave to my body. I told it to stop, but it still tracked me down. I did not want poverty to overtake me either. Bills got bigger while checks got smaller. I would speak, but fear, intimidation, and uncertainty would overpower me until I stopped executing the Word and began worrying again.

Then I discovered Jude's answer. Those who are sensual are sense-ruled, having not the Spirit. But beloved, because you have the Holy Ghost, you can build yourself up above that realm by praying in the Holy Ghost.

When I went full time, I had three little boys, no meetings, and no one wanted to hear me preach because I had never preached. The vision had panicked me, and I could not stay at the mill. Shortly after that I received Hagin and Copeland tapes. They established me in righteousness. I found out I was the righteousness of God in Christ by the new birth, saved by grace, and seated in heavenly places with Christ.

Then God taught me the walk of the Spirit: how the power of the Holy Spirit could be activated to mortify the flesh and clothe me with the inner man, created after God in righteousness and true holiness.

First He gave me the foundation of faith. Then He laid the walk of the Spirit on top of it, showing me how the characteristics of my flesh could change until the fruit of the Spirit came forth.

Praying in the Holy Ghost Builds You Above Fear's Final Say

In those early days we were living on a shoestring. Some nights I woke up in a cold sweat, seeing my children hungry and dressed in rags. At one point I broke under the pressure and applied for food stamps, but after all the hassle to get them, I went home and said, "I cannot do this." We gave them to a neighbor.

Faith was just beginning to come to me through the tapes, and I was just beginning to spend hours praying in the Holy Ghost. I did not know what it would do to my faith. I admired the Word. I admired the idea of standing in the face of poverty and disease and speaking the Word. But fear would knock me out of it.

So, not knowing what else to do, I kept praying. That prayer kept building me up on my most holy faith. Confidence began to come in the first two or three months. I found myself able to stand and speak the Word boldly without falling out of it.

When I made a contract with God and prayed the Word, I could stand on it like the rock of Gibraltar. My senses were being strengthened by edification from within because I had accidentally begun spending hour after hour praying in the Holy Ghost.

Many believers fall short of executing the Word because they do not have the edification and stamina that comes from praying in the Holy Ghost. If disease is eating your body, you may need to stand all night and describe the victory the Word has already won over that disease. But fear, dismay, and worry take many people out before they do it.

You know whether your senses dominate you by whether you obey the Word. If you do not do what the Word says, your senses still dominate that area.

The Holy Place in Prayer Is Peace Beyond Threatened Senses

There is a holy place in God where your senses cannot threaten you. When you enter that place, you find Him there. It is a place of victory and joy.

After about two months in the prayer closet, a woman came by and asked, "Are you feeling any difference?" I said, "Yes, ma'am. A dry throat, a tired chin, and a tired tongue." That was all I knew. I had been praying for hours in the Holy Ghost.

About a month later, she came by again. Her church was having a lay witness meeting, where laypeople from the denomination testified about what God was doing in their lives. They did not believe in speaking with tongues, but she had been baptized in the Holy Ghost under our ministry. She asked if I wanted to go to a home meeting.

I was excited for any opportunity to get out of the prayer closet. I ran home, changed clothes, and arrived late, just as the fellowship was breaking up because a golden-tongued orator was about to speak.

He began with language so polished and lifeless that I soon became bored. I sat there shaking my coffee cup just to watch the little rings move to the edge.

Out of sheer boredom, I looked at the elderly woman beside me. Suddenly, in my spirit, it was as if God put an X-ray between us. I saw a hip section, darkened, extending three or four inches down into her leg. I blinked, but it remained.

I asked, "Ma'am, do you have a problem in your hip?" Before I could finish, the word "arthritis" jumped out. She said, "Why, young man, that is what the doctor tells me."

I had arrived late and did not know she had come in on a crutch. I said, "Glory to God." She said, "I beg your pardon?" I said, "You are going to be healed. May I pray for you?"

To her, prayer meant that sometime during the day I would bow my head and remember her. To me, that was not what it meant. When she said yes, I got on my knees in front of her, grabbed both ankles, and lifted them. One leg was two or three inches shorter because of the hip.

I could not watch, so I closed my eyes and prayed my hardest Pentecostal Holiness prayer: "In the name of Jesus!" Witnesses told me that at the first "Jesus," it cracked and popped and came out even. She was healed, but I did not know because I was afraid to look.

The orator sent his associate to break up the commotion. He arrived, saw the miracle, and was struck nearly dumb. The woman later chased them around with her crutch when they tried to say God had not done it.

The Gift of Faith Flooded My Senses With God's Reality

That afternoon another woman needed prayer. They called and asked if they could come to my house. I was about to say, "Bring every sick person you can find," but the Holy Ghost said, "Main auditorium." So I went to the church.

They tried to take me to a basement room so far below ground it needed sump pumps, but the Holy Ghost kept saying, "Main auditorium or nothing." So I insisted.

When they finally brought me into the main auditorium, someone said, "He wants to say something." I thought, "He does? What am I going to say?" Then the Holy Ghost fell on me. The anointing gripped me like a vise. I heard myself saying things so good I wanted to step out of my body and take notes.

Then I saw another vision. A man was sitting a few rows back, and I saw his shoulder section. I knew his shoulder was diseased and he could not lift it. I marched up, grabbed him by the wrist, and said, "In the name of Jesus!" He cried out, then realized it did not hurt.

That was the gift of faith. It makes you bold as a lion and floods your senses with God's reality. You look at a wheelchair and think like God: "Why leave them in it?"

The woman who could not bend was healed. A boy's cataracts came off. The rooms emptied out. I yelled, "Anybody want what I have?" and young people came forward and began receiving the Holy Ghost. People were running around trying to take pulses because they had never seen people under the power before.

I slipped out a side door and found an iron post to lean on. I was so in the Spirit that the Spirit of God began pouring through me in prophecy.

He said, "Son, this did not come on you because it was ordained from the foundation of the world. I would have given it to you long ago if I could have. It did not come because of your evangelistic call; many evangelists do not walk in this. It did not come because of creed, color, race, or anything else. You uncovered a spiritual law and operated it for three months."

That law was praying in the Holy Ghost until it built me up on my most holy faith, above a sensual, carnal, sense-dominated walk, into a place where I was willing to take the Word of God as the final say-so in my life.

Praying in the Spirit Trains the Heart Not to Doubt

Mark 11 says that you can say to the mountain, and if you do not doubt in your heart, you will have what you say. Thank God, we have found something we can do that affects the human heart, the very part Jesus told us not to doubt in.

After seventeen years, He is still bringing me to the place where I am ready to prostrate my entire life on one verse. There is a place in the Holy Ghost where you do not fall short of believing the Word until what it says comes to pass. That is walking beyond your senses.

As we begin these basics of prayer, understand that at the Prayer Center we are contending for the faith once delivered to the saints.

There are two ways we contend. One is collectively, as the body of Christ, when we meet together, share the Word, hold each other up, and pray for one another. The other is individually.

Concerning individual prayer, you cannot pray in tongues too much. But collective prayer is also vital. When we fill the auditorium together in prayer, God desires to use our corporate mind and flow through us as one body toward what He wants prayed.

If you hear a voice saying, "Do not come to corporate prayer anymore. Just pull aside and spend private time with God," that is a voice of separation. It is a lie, and it will not work. You need corporate prayer as much as individual prayer, just as you need the body of believers and not a life walked alone.

God Fellowships With the Change Prayer Produces

God is not impressed with your 6:00 to 7:00 prayer hour, or your 9:00 to 10:00 prayer hour, or the particular night we choose to gather for prayer. He is not keeping a tally.

You may pray three days and miss two, then fall under condemnation because you missed the two. But God does not fellowship with legalistic hours. He enjoys any time you spend with Him.

He fellowships with the change prayer produces in your life. If you prayed only three hours last year and it produced something wonderful in you, He comes into that place and fellowships with the change. He does not condemn you for the hours you did not pray.

Of course, if you spend more time in prayer, it will produce more change for Him to fellowship with. But if you do not, He does not condemn you for what you did not do. You are His child.

So we need the Word together, prayer together, praise together, church together, and we also need the individual life of meditation, speaking the Word, praying in tongues, and fellowshiping with God. If any voice tells you to exclude one or the other, it is not God.

During this month of prayer, pray as much as possible.